

## Chapter 147-1

79 Guanghai Road was the most unique building in Haizhou City.

A three-story red villa stood in the bustling city center, just one street away from a lively snack street and a vegetable market.

Both this alley and this villa had a strong sense of history.

What Gu Yixue was filming this time was a period drama.

Pushing the timeline back, it was the Republic of China era<sup>1</sup>—a time of war and turmoil, an era that produced talented scholars and beautiful women, and also an age of dazzling nightlife and extravagance.

Those who loved it truly loved it; those who hated it truly hated it.

There was quite a bit of information about it online, but it was all speculation.

The only things that had been released were the director's name and the drama's name, with just a simple one-line description: An idealistic love story.

As for what kind of idealism it was, nobody knew.

But with Gu Yixue's name attached, it was a hot favorite for awards.

Whether the box office would be good was uncertain, but it would definitely be nominated for film awards.

Before today, Liang Shi hadn't received the script at all. To be precise, none of the actors in this production had received it.

There wasn't even a character biography or story outline. It was only after arriving at 79 Guanghai Road that they learned Gu Yixue was planning to film a Republic-era drama.

Filming idealism in a period drama was indeed a very bold attempt.

It required a very unique approach and extremely dire circumstances—a genre that heavily depended on the script.

It seemed Gu Yixue was very confident in her script.

Liang Shi arrived at two-thirty, half an hour earlier than the time Gu Yixue had specified.

This villa had been used as a filming location by many production crews, and renting it was extremely difficult.

But Gu Yixue had managed to rent it.

As Liang Shi walked in, she observed the villa's design. It was indeed very beautiful, with every brick and tile carefully considered.

When she entered, Gu Yixue was the only one inside the villa, standing by the window smoking.

The window was an intricately carved decorative window that didn't block the wind well. Because they were afraid of damaging the villa's character, there was no heating inside—it was only slightly warmer than outside, and not by much.

It would probably be the same when filming.

Liang Shi had filmed at tourist attractions before. For places that needed to be protected, the crew had to be extremely careful about everything, afraid of damaging anything. If you really couldn't stand the cold, you could hold a hot water bottle against your chest.

But open flames were strictly prohibited.

Gu Yixue was dressed all in black, which didn't quite match the setting.

Her hair was tied in a high ponytail, making her look sharp and capable. She had a small, delicate oval face and wore gold-rimmed glasses. When she turned around at the sound of footsteps, Liang Shi thought she would also be quite suited for acting.

"You're here." Gu Yixue had one arm resting on the windowsill. She exhaled a ring of smoke that dispersed in front of her face, carrying an air of aloofness.

Liang Shi felt she looked even younger than what her profile suggested.

Perhaps it was because of that face.

But her eyes were as deep as the ocean, impossible to see through, carrying a maturity that didn't match her face.

It should have been a very contradictory quality, but it blended well on her.

"Mm." Liang Shi responded.

Gu Yixue had already sorted all the scripts and had even written names on the title page of each person's script.

For actors, this actually wasn't a good director—the first impression she gave was of being dictatorial.

Having everything done according to the director's wishes meant losing the actor's creative space. Some actors with too much ego would find it impossible to work with a director like Gu Yixue, and intense conflicts would arise.

But Liang Shi wasn't worried.

She was the type of actor who could find a good balance between the director's requirements and her own artistic expression. Moreover, for Gu Yixue, she had completed the script independently—she understood the characters she had written better than anyone else. She didn't need others to do reading comprehension.

The most important point was that she could take responsibility for the characters she wrote.

What she wanted and what the actors needed to present should be the same thing.

No one could understand the characters better than the screenwriter herself.

This was why Liang Shi unconditionally trusted Gu Yixue.

Even though there were only the two of them in the room, they didn't talk much—there wasn't even basic small talk.

---

### **Footnotes:**

<sup>1</sup> Republic of China era (民國): The period from 1912 to 1949 in mainland China, following the fall of the Qing Dynasty. It was a turbulent time marked by warlord conflicts, Japanese invasion, and civil war, but also a period of cultural flourishing and modernization in cities like Shanghai. This era is a popular setting for Chinese period dramas due to its blend of traditional and modern elements, and its romantic yet tragic backdrop.

## Chapter 147-2

Gu Yixue finished smoking by the window, waved her hand to disperse the smell, closed the window, pulled her coat tighter, and returned to her seat.

Liang Shi, however, was completely absorbed in reading the script.

The main storyline of Gu Yixue's film was simple—it was about two women finding mutual redemption in turbulent times. Talking about ideals during chaotic times was no different from a pipe dream, yet they dared to talk about them.

The film focused heavily on a woman named Huang Shan. She was a woman who had been influenced by new progressive ideas—she attended school, participated in movements, ran about calling for civil rights, had been thrown in prison, had been subjected to mob justice, yet still continued to explore this path.

It could be said that she had devoted everything to this era of chaos.

Not a single day passed without her yearning for the chaos to end and for peace under heaven.

The other female lead, Guan Qingmin, grew up in a private school<sup>1</sup>. She was well-versed in the Four Books and Five Classics<sup>2</sup>, and the most unconventional book she had ever read was "Dream of the Red Chamber"<sup>3</sup>. Her daily life consisted of reading and embroidery, confined to her chambers for over a decade.

Guan Qingmin's parents had arranged her marriage early on—to the son of her father's colleague. This man was greedy and lecherous, frequenting brothels regularly. But because his father could assist her father in his official career, Guan Qingmin's father had her become engaged to him.

Guan Qingmin's father was a typical traitor in these turbulent times. He held immense power in Guangping City, but it was power gained through collaborating with the enemy and betraying his country.

The students in Guangping City hated him to the bone, wishing he would die in the Pu River as soon as possible.

Huang Shan was their representative.

An extremely stark contrast between characters.

Yet Guan Qingmin was saved by Huang Shan during an outing. Huang Shan thought she was just a daughter from an ordinary family. With the external environment being dangerous at the time, Huang Shan brought her back to her own home.

But Guan Qingmin fell in love with this woman at first sight and pretended to have amnesia to stay by her side.

Huang Shan pitied her and treated her extremely well.

In the midst of chaos, the two spent unforgettable days together, supporting each other as feelings quietly grew between them.

Huang Shan told Guan Qingmin about these turbulent times, about her ideals, and gave Guan Qingmin meticulous care.

In Guan Qingmin's heart, Huang Shan was the perfect lover.

But the web woven from lies was like bubbles—it all shattered the day the Guan family found her.

Huang Shan was heartbroken; Guan Qingmin washed her face with tears.

For Huang Shan's safety, Guan Qingmin left with her father and received very harsh punishment.

Huang Shan was depressed for several days before pulling herself together.

A plague spread through Guangping City. Huang Shan fell ill, and Guan Qingmin came to care for her.

The fire that had dimmed was rekindled. Guan Qingmin told her: "My father doesn't know."

Guan Qingmin was so careful and cautious around her that it broke Huang Shan's heart.

The two, just beginning to understand the taste of love, faced an impossible situation. In the end, on the night before her wedding, Guan Qingmin chose to flee from those high walls and grand courtyards, asking Huang Shan to take her away.

Huang Shan asked: "Where can we run to? Your father's spies are everywhere."

Guan Qingmin said: "Anywhere is fine."

So the two fled that deep night, only to be found at dawn the next day.

But what the Guan family's people found were only two corpses.

Two bodies lying quietly on the sandy beach by the sea, with the sea breeze continuously blowing past. They slept in silence.

This employed the technique of leaving blank space<sup>4</sup>, but after the blank space, one could continue searching for answers.

It turned out that after the two escaped outside the city, Huang Shan decided to send her away first while she herself would stay in Guangping City to continue the struggle.

Because there was still a major event that needed her to lead—this was her mission.

If she didn't go, many of her classmates would lose their lives.

But if she went, Guan Qingmin's parents would lose their lives.

An impossible dilemma.

The two stood by the sea. Guan Qingmin took out a gun and handed it to Huang Shan.

Huang Shan immediately understood what she meant.

And so, by the sea, the two ended their lives.

It was a BE<sup>5</sup>.

Turbulent times were always full of tragedies, especially loves that could never be.

The script had many blank spaces. On the first read, the two protagonists' actions seemed difficult to understand, but one would be shaken by the emotions within.

Reading the script a second time with those questions about the two protagonists, one would discover that all the tragedy had been foreshadowed.

It truly was an idealistic love.

The most ideal, most romantic ending was nothing more than ignoring the mortal world and letting everything end.

Their lives and their love ended at the same time.

In this era when sweet love stories prevailed, one had to admit that Gu Yixue really dared to write.

Even in the final scene where both died, it was Huang Shan who first killed Guan Qingmin, then shot herself in the heart.

This was an extreme test of human nature.

Unsurprisingly, this shot would definitely be a very slow shot, meant to make the audience's hearts clench.

But when Liang Shi asked Gu Yixue, Gu Yixue said: "Fast shot."

The second after Huang Shan shot Guan Qingmin, Huang Shan would without hesitation turn the gun on herself.

Only this kind of ending was worthy of the title—"Mo Journey."

After reading the script and hearing Gu Yixue's words, Liang Shi was filled with admiration. All she could say was that Gu Yixue dared to challenge human nature.

And she could find a balance between love and human nature.

Whether this script would become popular, Liang Shi didn't know.

But Liang Shi really liked this script.

She asked Gu Yixue which role she had been assigned.

---

## Footnotes:

<sup>1</sup> Private school (私塾, sīshú): Traditional Chinese private schools that taught Confucian classics, typically for children from wealthy families. These were different from modern schools and focused on classical education.

<sup>2</sup> Four Books and Five Classics (四書五經): The foundational texts of Confucianism that formed the core curriculum of traditional Chinese education. They include works like the Analects of Confucius and the Book of Changes.

<sup>3</sup> "Dream of the Red Chamber" (紅樓夢): One of China's Four Great Classical Novels, written in the 18th century. It was considered somewhat scandalous for its time due to its romantic themes and critique of feudal society, hence why reading it would be "unconventional" for a sheltered young lady.

<sup>4</sup> Leaving blank space (留白): A narrative technique in Chinese storytelling and art where certain details are deliberately left unsaid or unshown, allowing the audience to fill in the gaps with their imagination. It creates a sense of artistic restraint and deeper emotional impact.

<sup>5</sup> BE: Stands for "Bad Ending," internet slang commonly used in Chinese fan communities to indicate a story with a tragic or unhappy ending, as opposed to "HE" (Happy Ending).

## Chapter 147-3

Gu Yixue raised an eyebrow and teased with a light laugh: "You dare to act in my production without even knowing which role you're playing?"

"I hadn't even seen the script before coming, yet I still came, didn't I?" Liang Shi countered lightly.

Gu Yixue nodded: "Quite bold."

Liang Shi smiled: "It's alright. After all, it's a production by an internationally renowned director—there's no way I'd be at a loss."

Gu Yixue curled her fingers and tapped them on the table a few times: "Which role do you want to play?"

Hearing this, Liang Shi said: "Guan Qingmin."

Liang Shi had never challenged this type of role before. She felt her personality was somewhat similar to Guan Qingmin's—both were the slightly wooden type, and both yearned for freedom.

She could portray that feeling of being confined.

But Gu Yixue said: "You'll play Huang Shan."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Is there a problem?" Gu Yixue asked her.

Liang Shi: ".....No."

It was obvious that Huang Shan had far more scenes than Guan Qingmin.

In fact, Guan Qingmin's character existed to highlight Huang Shan's decisiveness and fearlessness.

Compared to Huang Shan, Guan Qingmin was indeed somewhat flat as a character. Her best moment was only at the end, in the scene where she handed over the gun.

And that was precisely the scene Liang Shi had her eye on.

In that moment, she would have enough space to express Guan Qingmin's emotions.

—Because I love you, I can place my life in your hands and trust you unconditionally.

The character would be elevated in that instant.

But Gu Yixue said: "You're more suited for Huang Shan."

Liang Shi: "....."



Liang Shi felt that Gu Yixue didn't understand her well enough, but she was also willing to challenge this role.

And she trusted Gu Yixue's vision and judgment.

Sometimes actors weren't as perceptive about their own positioning as directors were.

Besides, Liang Shi had a creed as an actress: Never play Liang Shi.

This was a very important point.

An actor should become whoever they play, not make every character seem like themselves.

She readily accepted Gu Yixue's suggestion. Before she could say anything more, the others began arriving one after another.

The first to arrive was Sun Chengcheng. She wore a white turtleneck sweater paired with an off-white long coat, looking pure and cute. Her eyes were especially striking—a light brown color.

Though that was from colored contact lenses.

Because Liang Shi had met her before, and her eyes were the darker type—eyes full of spirit and vitality.

Two others came after her, one named Qi Tang and one named Tang Zui.

Their names were quite coincidentally connected<sup>1</sup>. The two looked like different types, but each had their own distinctive features.

The moment Sun Chengcheng came in and saw Liang Shi, she immediately showed a look of disgust.

But upon seeing Gu Yixue, she put away the disgust and greeted Gu Yixue with a smile: "Hello, Director."

Gu Yixue nodded slightly and said expressionlessly: "Read the script first."

Gu Yixue, who got straight to the point, was very cool. So while waiting for them to read the script, Liang Shi read through it once more.

After waiting about ten minutes or so, Sun Chengcheng was moved to tears. While wiping her tears and sniffing, she asked Gu Yixue: "Director, why is it a tragedy?"

Gu Yixue: "....."

As if not expecting such a question, Gu Yixue paused for two seconds before answering coldly: "Because I like it."

This was also Gu Yixue's first BE work.

Sun Chengcheng had just wiped away her tears and hadn't had time to compose herself when she heard Gu Yixue ask: "Who do you plan to play?"

Sun Chengcheng answered without thinking: "Huang Shan."

Gu Yixue: "....."

Two seconds later, Gu Yixue said decisively: "You'll play Guan Qingmin."

Sun Chengcheng: "?"

She instinctively looked toward Liang Shi, her expression very unfriendly.

But Liang Shi didn't pay attention. She lowered her head and continued reading the script, only glancing at Sun Chengcheng with a look of disdain as her eyes swept past.

She was channeling that energy she used when playing Zhao Xuning—it seemed to work quite well.

Because Sun Chengcheng immediately stopped crying.

Sun Chengcheng questioned Gu Yixue: "Director, why?"

Gu Yixue paused again: "There is no why."

Sun Chengcheng: "....."

---

### Footnotes:

<sup>1</sup> Names coincidentally connected: The two names Qi Tang (祁唐) and Tang Zui (唐醉) both contain the character "Tang" (唐), making them sound like they share a connection or could be related, hence the comment about their names being "quite coincidentally connected" (有緣分, literally "having fate/destiny together").